

STUDENT TOOLKIT | 2026

SCIENCE JOURNAL

The paper trail that proves the work is yours.

Print and bind, or keep the pages in a folder. One journal per student.



THIS JOURNAL BELONGS TO

Student name: _____

Grade and class: _____

School: _____

Project question: _____

Teacher: _____

WHY THIS JOURNAL MATTERS

Judges and teachers read this journal to see how you actually worked. Write in it every time you touch the project, even for short sessions. Write in pen and never erase. Cross out mistakes with a single line so the original stays readable. Messy and complete beats neat and missing.

JOURNAL CHECK DATES

Your teacher collects this journal four times. Write the dates in as soon as you get them.

Check 1, end of week 3	Question is testable, hypothesis written, one source cited	_____ date
Check 2, end of week 6	Design complete, procedure written, materials identified	_____ date
Check 3, end of week 9	Data collection underway, data table has real entries	_____ date
Check 4, end of week 12	Complete record from start to finish	_____ date

WHAT GOES IN THIS JOURNAL

Everything below belongs in the journal. If you are unsure whether something counts, write it down. Nothing gets left out for being too small.

- Date and time of every work session, even short ones
- Written observations during every trial: what you saw, heard, or measured
- Questions that came up, and how you answered them
- Sketches, diagrams, and draft data tables
- Notes from any interview, mentor conversation, or background reading
- A running log of hours worked on the project
- Any time your original plan changed, and why it changed

ABOUT ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

A genuine journal cannot be faked after the fact. Dated entries, real measurements, and sketches from the day you took them are what tell a judge this project is yours. That protection only works if you write as you go.

HOURS LOG

Total each week. Judges often ask how long a project took.

WEEK	HOURS	WEEK	HOURS	WEEK	HOURS

ENTRY

Date: _____ Time in / out: _____ Today's goal: _____

WHAT I DID

MEASUREMENTS AND DATA

OBSERVATIONS, SKETCHES, AND QUESTIONS

WHAT CHANGED FROM MY PLAN, AND WHY

NEXT STEP

ENTRY

Date: _____ Time in / out: _____ Today's goal: _____

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